

Poll-U-Shun



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Last month I had a severe bout of cough, a constant source of irritation while it lasted. Shortly after the cold ran its course, Siddharth started coughing up a storm for a few days. All this persistent coughing ringing through my ears made me wonder if there was more than just the cold bug to blame for our predicament. What if this was an early effect of the stratospheric levels of pollution in our city?

After digging for some numbers, I found that we Mumbaitees have it better, for what it's worth, compared to our North Indian brethren when it comes to inhaling polluted air. Thanks to a live online air quality index unveiled by the Central Pollution Control Board in April this year (<http://aqi.iitk.ac.in>), it's clearly visible that Delhi (and other major northern Indian cities) needs a pollution intervention fast, because the pollution there is severely out of control. If Mumbai's pollution is bad, then Delhi's and its surrounding area's air quality is downright poisonous.

While awareness is a good start, more work needs to be done. The government moves slowly and can only do so much, and the shift to a greener alternative fuel isn't going to happen in a hurry. As responsible citizens, with the help of technology companies, we need to take the lead on tackling this growing menace, gather data through crowdsourced initiatives, analyse the evidence of pollution in our locality and take some concrete steps towards rescuing the situation. All's not lost yet. Let me point out a few examples here.

Small sensor-based wearable devices like 'Breathe' and others that sit inside ('Nest' and 'Birdi') as well as outside your house ('Air Quality Egg') are already available for consumers to monitor their surrounding air quality and upload the readings on a central website. However, all this is disorganised. After all, how many people will really chip in? The pollution watch effort needs to be incentivised, like it is in the Chinese market. Xiaomi – a brand that's making all sorts of waves in the Indian smartphone market – sells the 'Mi Air Purifier' in China. It conveniently sends pollution readings from in and around your home to mobile phones to alert users of high level of contaminants (if any).

China has an even bigger pollution problem than our country, where besides implementing automobile bans (already in place), much more needs to be done to bring down pollution levels in the air, water and soil. One man's trash is another man's treasure, and it can't be more truer in the case of Chinese enterprises trying to crack the pollution code. Technology titans like Alibaba, Baidu and Xiaomi have all come to treat pollution awareness as a new market to build and sell pollution sensing devices. Alibaba and Baidu released water pollution kits last year, things that can test salt level, pH, oil quality and other harmful waste residue in water, and these things are quite affordable – Alibaba, for instance, sells its kits for about ₹ 650 each.

If Chinese companies can do this, what's stopping Indian companies from entering the pollution watch market? Maybe striving to save the environment doesn't rank as high up as making profits in their 'to-do' list.

But if you thought health hazards can be averted and pollution can be lowered by simply reducing the number of cars on the road, think again. Our indulgence in technology and over dependence on gadgets means a lot of rare minerals, that are hard to procure and difficult to dispose, are harming us in the long run. One way to tackle this is by making it mandatory for technology manufacturers to release a detailed disclaimer on what potentially harmful elements go into the gadgets they make and sell – akin to "no animals were harmed during the making of this movie". Public advocacy groups and citizen watchdogs can remain vigilant on these companies' claims.

Clearly, we aren't making the pollution riddle any easier to solve. But we need to grow up, come of age and do our bit to save the environment, instead of passing the buck. Just like Gandhi urged us to consume Swadeshi goods during the Independence movement, we need to reward the brands and buy products that do their bit to preserve our ecology. ■

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